

32 Conditional tenses

You can use the third conditional to describe an unreal past, or events that did not happen. This is useful for talking about regrets you have about the past.

 **New language** The third conditional

Aa Vocabulary Environmental threats

 **New skill** Talking about an unreal past

32.1 KEY LANGUAGE THE THIRD CONDITIONAL

SECOND CONDITIONAL

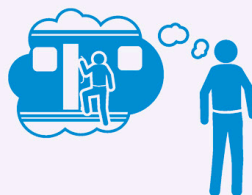
The second conditional is used to describe unreal situations in the present.



If I lived in New York,
I would go running in Central Park.

THIRD CONDITIONAL

Use the third conditional to describe unreal situations in the past.



If we had left earlier,
we would have caught the train.



32.2 HOW TO FORM THE THIRD CONDITIONAL

"IF"

"HAD" + PAST PARTICIPLE

"WOULD / COULD / MIGHT"

"HAVE" + PAST PARTICIPLE

If

we had left earlier,

we would

have caught the train.

The "if" clause is the unreal past condition.

Using different modals varies the certainty of the imagined result.

The conditional clause is the unreal result.

32.3 ANOTHER WAY TO SAY THE THIRD CONDITIONAL

The past perfect continuous can also follow "if" in the third conditional.

If you'd been wearing a coat, you would have stayed warm.

We would've caught the train if we'd left on time.

Often "have" is contracted when spoken.

Sentences in the third conditional can be reordered without a comma so the "if" clause is second.

